

Day 7 — *Iṣopaniṣad* Mantra 1: Use, Don't Grab

Module: Indic Ecology · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students recite *Iṣopaniṣad* mantra 1, identify the three injunctions it contains (treat all as enveloped by the divine; enjoy by renouncing; do not covet), and apply the “use, don't grab” ethic to one specific consumption habit of their own.

Materials

- Printed handout: *Iṣopaniṣad* mantra 1 in IAST + translation, one per student
- Notebook
- Whiteboard

Vocabulary

- *īśa* (IAST: *īśa*; lit. “lord, controller”) — the supreme principle / divinity. The Upaniṣad is named after the first word of mantra 1.
- *īśāvāsyā* (IAST: *īśāvāsyā*) — “to-be-enveloped-by-the-lord,” i.e. permeated by the divine.
- *jagat* (IAST: *jagat*; lit. “what moves”) — the moving / changing world.
- *tyakta* (IAST: *tyakta*; lit. “renounced, given up”) — what is given up, set aside, surrendered.
- *bhujñīthāḥ* (IAST: *bhujñīthāḥ*) — “you may enjoy / partake / use.”
- *grdhaḥ* (IAST: *grdhaḥ*; lit. “grasping, coveting”) — greed, desire to grab.
- *ahiṃsā* (IAST: *ahiṃsā*; lit. “non-harm”) — non-injury to living beings; the first of Patañjali's five *yamas*. (Bridge from Module 8.)

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- On the board: “Name one thing you used today that wasn't yours.” (Air. Sunlight. The road. The bench. The teacher's time.)
- Take 4–5 quick answers.
- “Now — did you ‘grab’ it, or ‘use’ it? What's the difference?” Don't resolve. The mantra resolves it.

Core (20 min)

1. **Read the mantra together** — students follow along on the handout:

“*īśāvāsyam idaṃ sarvaṃ yat kiñca jagatyāṃ jagat / tena tyaktena bhujñīthā mā grdhaḥ kasya svid dhanam //*”

“All this — whatever moves in this moving world — is enveloped by the Lord. By that renunciation, enjoy. Do not covet anyone’s wealth.” — Īśa Upaniṣad, mantra 1

2. **Three injunctions in one verse.** Number them on the board:

1. **All this is enveloped by the Lord.** Nothing is yours by default. Everything is, in some sense, on loan.
 2. **By that renunciation, enjoy.** Use what is given. Take what is needed. Don’t claim ownership beyond what you actually use.
 3. **Do not covet anyone’s wealth.** Don’t grab what is not yours — neither another person’s, nor another being’s, nor nature’s.
3. **The phrase *tena tyaktena bhuñjīthāḥ*** is the most quoted half-line. Two readings exist among traditional commentators:
- **Śaṅkara’s reading:** “renounce, then enjoy.” First give up the sense of ownership; then use.
 - **Other commentators:** “enjoy what is left over.” First the gods, the ancestors, and the community get their share; then enjoy what remains.

Both readings produce the same ecological ethic: *use, do not grab*.

4. **Why this is ecology.** Modern environmental crises — climate, biodiversity loss, water shortage — are not crises of “use.” They are crises of “grab.” Every human civilisation has used the environment. Most cultures, including the Indic tradition, accepted that use as necessary. But the Indic tradition (in this verse) sets a clear limit: *use is fine, grab is not*.
5. **Link to *ahimsā*.** The first of Patañjali’s *yamas* (eight-limbed yoga, from Module 8) is *ahimsā* — non-harm. Indic ethics extends *ahimsā* beyond humans:
- Don’t kill what you don’t need to kill.
 - Don’t waste what you took.
 - Don’t take from a being’s last resource.

This is why traditional dietary patterns avoided gratuitous killing; why old laws forbade cutting fruit trees during fruiting; why traditional kitchens kept a portion of cooked rice aside for crows.

These are *ahimsā-shaped* practices, not just rituals.

Activity (15 min) — “What do I grab without asking?”

- Each student takes 5 minutes alone with their notebook.
- Prompt: “List five specific things you took today without asking — and decide, for each, whether you ‘used’ it or ‘grabbed’ it.”
- Examples to seed:
 - Took 5 sheets of printer paper for 2 sheets of work. ← Grab.
 - Drank a glass of water at the school cooler. ← Use.
 - Threw away half a plate of food at lunch. ← Grab.

- Listened to a teacher’s full explanation. ← Use.
- Cut a flower off the plant for fun. ← Grab.
- Pairs share two from their list. Pairs help each other classify.
- **Whole-class discussion (5 min):** “Of the grabs we listed — which is the easiest one to stop? Which is the hardest? Why?”

Wrap-up (5 min)

- **Exit ticket** (slip of paper): “My one specific habit-grab from now on will be a use, not a grab. Specifically: I will _____ instead of _____.”
- Preview Day 8: “Tomorrow we look at the biggest grab humanity is collectively making — climate change. Then we put the framework to work.”

Student-facing content

Iṣopaniṣad mantra 1:

“īśāvāsyam idaṁ sarvaṁ yat kiñca jagatyāṁ jagat / tena tyaktena bhuñjīthā mā
grdhaḥ kasya svid dhanam //”

“All this — whatever moves in this moving world — is enveloped by the Lord. By that renunciation, enjoy. Do not covet anyone’s wealth.”

The verse gives three rules:

1. Nothing is yours by default.
2. Use what is given. Don’t claim more.
3. Don’t grab from anyone — human, being, or planet.

The Indic tradition extended *ahimsā* (non-harm) to all of life. Don’t harm what you don’t need to harm. Don’t waste what you took. Don’t take from a being’s last resource.

Homework

- Pick one *grab* from your list today. For 24 hours, replace it with a *use*. Be specific. Bring tomorrow a 3-sentence note on whether it worked.

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Compare *tena tyaktena bhuñjīthāḥ* with the modern concept of “the commons” (a resource shared by a community, with rules against private grabbing). Elinor Ostrom won the 2009 Nobel in Economics for showing how communities self-organise to manage commons. What does the Upaniṣad add that economics doesn’t?
- **One tier down:** Memorise just the second half of the mantra: “By renouncing, enjoy. Do not covet anyone’s wealth.” That’s the practical rule.

Teacher notes

- The Sanskrit *bhuñjīthāḥ* is the optative form of *bhuj* — “to enjoy, eat, partake.” Translators often use “enjoy”; “use” or “partake” works equally well.

- Some students will ask, “But this is asking me to give up things — isn’t that asceticism?” Push back gently: no, the verse says *enjoy*. The renunciation is of *grasping*, not of using. You can enjoy your meal; the renunciation is the *attitude* that says “this is mine and only mine.”
- *gr̥dhaḥ* (the second-person prohibition: “do not grab”) shares a root with “vulture” (*gr̥dhra*). The image is sharp. You can use it.
- Avoid moralising. The exercise is about *noticing* the distinction between use and grab. Most adults haven’t done this exercise. The students will do it more honestly than we will.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- **Īśa Upaniṣad mantra 1** — quoted in IAST with translation. Text per the standard Mādhyandina recension; identical to Śukla Yajur Veda 40.1.
- See `sources.md` for editions used.